

The Illusion of Team Alignment Under Pressure

CASE CLASSIFICATION	
CONDITION TYPE	Hidden Divergence
DOMAIN	Team Governance / Execution Coherence
CONFIDENCE	High
RELEVANCE	Restructuring decisions, team investment, governance reporting accuracy
EVIDENCE BASIS	
[OBSERVED]	Leadership self-assessment (4 domains)
[OBSERVED]	Team respondent scores (n=34)
[OBSERVED]	OKR/reporting gap analysis
[INFERRED]	Restructuring impact projection

Mid-size firm. Leadership reported 85% alignment. Team respondents (n=34) scored 42–58%.

PRIMARY SIGNALS

- Leadership rated alignment at 85% across 4 domains
- Team respondents scored 42–58% on same domains
- Gap not visible in performance reviews, OKRs, or management reporting

SECONDARY SIGNALS

- Highest divergence in Strategic Alignment (85% vs 42%)
- Narrowest gap in Operational Velocity (80% vs 58%)
- Exit interview data retrospectively consistent with divergence

SYSTEM INTERPRETATION

Alignment assumed at top, contradicted at base. Standard governance did not detect.

SYSTEM CLASSIFICATION

HIDDEN DIVERGENCE

Aligned !' Structurally Fractured

COUNTERFACTUAL

WRONG ACTION

Proceeding with restructuring based on leadership's alignment reading.

RESULT OF THAT PATH

Intervention would have amplified divergence. Projected dissonance increase from 30–43 to 50–65 points within 90 days.

DECISION FRAME

REQUIRED DECISION

Halt restructuring. Measure execution-layer alignment before structural change.

CONSTRAINTS

- Restructuring already approved by board
- Leadership confidence in alignment was high
- No precedent for overriding leadership self-assessment

OUTCOME / IMPLICATIONS

- Alignment cannot be assessed from the top — must be measured at execution level
- Restructuring under assumed alignment carries compounding risk
- Standard governance instruments do not detect perception divergence

BOARD-LEVEL ACTIONS

01	Require execution-layer alignment measurement before restructuring
02	Add team perception gap to governance risk register
03	Mandate bi-annual Team Assessment for units above 20 headcount
04	Flag leadership self-assessment as insufficient for structural decisions

SYSTEM TRACE

- Diagnostics — Team Assessment / perception gap measurement
- Mandate Clarity Framework — Authority divergence detection
- Executive Reporting — Team coherence index

“What leadership believes about alignment is not evidence. Measurement is.”